

Culture Unit (III)

漢字介紹 — An Introduction to Chinese Characters: The Six Etymological Principles

Let's Learn Mandarin · Book 1

Illustration: Gloria holds up a piece of paper with a character written on it.

Gloria: What character is this that you've written? Mingwen: It's the character 月 — the 月 in "August" (八月). Gloria: 月? I can write 月 too — but not like that!

According to the principles by which Chinese characters were created and used, characters are divided into six major categories, commonly known as the "Six Scripts" (六書, liù shū). The Six Scripts are: pictographs (象形), indicatives (指事), logical aggregates (會意), phono-semantic compounds (形聲), derivative cognates (轉注), and phonetic loans (假借).

The "Six Scripts" is a system in which Xu Shen of the Eastern Han dynasty categorized Chinese characters according to the rules of their formation and usage, and compiled them into a book called the *Shuowen Jiezi* (說文解字). In the preface to that work, Xu Shen gave a brief definition of each of the Six Scripts and provided two example characters for each.

The Shuowen Jiezi states:

- ◆ **Pictographs (象形):** Draw the shape of the thing; compress the body to fit the form. 日 (sun) and 月 (moon) are examples.
- ◆ **Indicatives (指事):** Perceivable by sight, comprehensible on inspection. 上 (above) and 下 (below) are examples.
- ◆ **Logical aggregates (會意):** Compare and combine categories; perceive the meaning from the joined elements. 武 (martial) and 信 (trustworthy) are examples.
- ◆ **Phono-semantic compounds (形聲):** Name the thing with a semantic component; take a complementary sound component. 江 (river) and 河 (waterway) are examples.
- ◆ **Derivative cognates (轉注):** Build a category heading; share the same meaning. 考 (to test) and 老 (old) are examples.
- ◆ **Phonetic loans (假借):** No character originally existed for the word; the sound is borrowed to record it. 令 (to command) and 長 (long/chief) are examples.

The Shuowen Jiezi records over nine thousand Chinese characters, of which phono-semantic compounds are the most numerous.

1. 象形字 — Pictographs

Pictographs are characters formed by drawing the shape of a real object using simple lines — that is, depicting the appearance of what is being expressed as a picture or abstract outline.

Character	Pronunciation	Meaning	Evolution
日	rì	sun	☀ → ☉ → 𠄎 → 日
月	yuè	moon	🌙 → 月 (oracle) → 月 (seal) → 月
馬	mǎ	horse	🐎 → 𠂇 (oracle) → 𠂇 (seal) → 馬

2. 指事字 — Indicatives

Indicatives are an ancient method of forming characters using symbolic signs to express meaning. When what a character needs to express is not a concrete object but an abstract concept, pictographic methods cannot be used — only more abstract symbols will do.

Character	Pronunciation	Meaning	Evolution
上	shàng	above	[symbol with line above] → 𠂇 → 上
下	xià	below	[symbol with line below] → 𠂇 → 下

3. 會意字 — Logical Aggregates

Logical aggregates are characters formed by combining two or more independent characters according to the logic of their meanings to express a new meaning. A logical aggregate must combine two or more individual characters, and from seeing them together, the meaning of what is indicated becomes clear — thus forming a new compound character.

Character	Pronunciation	Meaning	Evolution
休	xiū	rest (a person leaning against a tree, indicating “resting”)	👤 → 𠂇 → 𠂇 → 休
林	lín	grove (if there are two trees, there is a grove)	🌲 🌲 → 𠂇 → 𠂇 → 林

4. 形聲字 — Phono-Semantic Compounds

Phono-semantic compounds are characters formed by combining a semantic component (indicating meaning) and a phonetic component (indicating pronunciation) to create a new character.

Character	Pronunciation	Meaning	Components
媽	mā	mother	女 (nǚ) — meaning: woman + 馬 sound (mǎ)
烤	kǎo	to bake	火 (huǒ) — meaning: fire + 考 sound (kǎo)

5. 轉注字 — Derivative Cognates

Derivative cognates are characters that belong to the same radical category, have similar pronunciations, share the same meaning, and can be used to explain each other. They can be thought of as derivatives or borrowings of a character — one meaning expressed by multiple characters. Derivative cognates must exist in pairs or groups. For example: 考 and 老.

6. 假借字 — Phonetic Loans

Phonetic loans refer to words that exist in spoken language but for which no written character exists. An existing character with the same sound is borrowed to record that word. When a new thing appeared and a spoken word for it already existed, but no character had yet been created to represent it, a character with the same pronunciation would be borrowed to stand in its place — this is phonetic borrowing. For example: 止 (whose original meaning was “the sole of a person’s foot”) is now used in the sense of 停止 (to stop/cease).

Cultural Note: The Six Scripts are not simply six different “ways to write” characters — they are a framework for understanding how the Chinese writing system developed across thousands of years. Pictographs and indicatives form the foundation; logical aggregates and phono-semantic compounds account for the vast majority of characters in use today. Phono-semantic compounds alone make up roughly 80-90% of all Chinese characters, which is why recognizing semantic and phonetic components is one of the most powerful tools for learning to read and write Chinese.

[Pages 132-133: Blank note pages for teacher use]